Joint Staff Headquarters Lt Gen. Tabassum Habib have both visited Dhaka recently.

Of course, the Chinese are in the mix too. Under a $2.2 billion deal China will deliver 20 J-10CE fighter jets to Bangladesh, joint drone factories have opened, Mongla and Chattogram ports are being upgraded by Beijing, and the Golden Friendship-2024 counter-terror drills between the People's Liberation Army (PLA) and Bangladesh Army continued well into 2025. The signs for India were clear when China hosted a foreign office consultation with Pakistani and Bangladeshi counterparts in Kunming in June 2025—Dhaka has picked its side. Shreyas Deshmukh, a research fellow at the Delhi Policy Group, argues that it is political turmoil in Bangladesh that opened the space there for China and Pakistan.

THE DOKLAM WARNING

Beyond an increasingly adversarial Bangladesh's machinations, the Siliguri Corridor lies only 25-30 km from the border trijunction of India, Bhutan and China. The 73-day standoff in 2017 between the PLA and the Indian Army at the Doklam plateau—south of the Chumbi Valley in Tibet—showed how vulnerable the corridor is. India's response there was aimed at supporting Bhutan against China's attempt to extend its road network through an unresolved border area. Military planners have expressed concern that China might try to use its sizable military assets in Chumbi through Doklam to cut off the corridor. Observers say that the face-off was triggered when the PLA tried to build a road from Chumbi southwards towards the high ground of the Jompheri Ridge overlooking the corridor—a clear attempt at threatening it.

Deshmukh red flags another threat—impending Chinese participation in Bangladesh's Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project, involving flood control, riverbed deepening and land reclamation. When implemented, it would bring significant Chinese presence dangerously close to the Siliguri Corridor. In the recent past, the corridor has been used as a transit route by insurgent groups like the ULFA, Bodo Liberation Tigers Force and Kamtapur Liberation Organisation. There are concerns about the possible resurgence of these groups with the support of ISI and China.

However, the corridor's low hills, forests, rivers and broken terrain provide strong defensive lines. Military planners have explored several-worst case scenarios, including airborne raids, through war-games. Troops, including mechanised forces, are fully prepared and regularly practice for such possibilities. Maj. Gen. Alok Deb (retd), who has served in the region, emphasises that the upgradation of military infrastructure in the Siliguri Corridor is a continuous process. "While it is very difficult for enemy land forces to simply overrun the corridor, such an attempt could be complemented and enabled by air force elements. Therefore, the Indian military must continue to substantially strengthen its rapid-reaction capabilities," he says.

New Delhi has realised that China, Pakistan and Bangladesh are a 'collaborative threat' to India near the corridor. The three new army bases, the military feels, give it enough teeth to meet any aggression in the area. ■

AVOIDING A STRANGLE

The reasons why the army set up three new garrisons around the Siliguri Corridor

- **Bangladesh's alarming new and wide defence ties with Pakistan, with presence of ISI agents near the corridor**
- **Modernisation of Lalmonirhat airbase just 16 km from the corridor with alleged Pakistani help**
- **Construction of large hangar in nearby Haribhanga, capable of housing fighters, drones**
- **When activated, they would enable Pakistan/China surveillance of Indian army installations, troop movements**
- **Doklam plateau at the India-China-Bhutan trijunction, site of the PLA-Indian army standoff in 2017, is only around 25-30 km from the corridor**
- **Chinese participation in Bangladesh's Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project would bring Chinese presence close to the Siliguri Corridor**
- **The corridor was a transit route by insurgent groups like the ULFA, Bodo Liberation Tigers Force and Kamtapur Liberation Organisation**
- **There are concerns about their resurgence with ISI/ Chinese support**



"It is very difficult for enemy land forces to overrun the corridor, but it could be enabled by its air force. The military must continue to strengthen its rapid-reaction capabilities"

MAJ. GEN. ALOK DEB *(Retd)*
Former Deputy Director General, Manohar Parrikar Institute of Defence Studies and Analyses